

CASTING THEIR NET
Fishermen on the Teesta in north Bengal

AFP

KEEPING HASINA WAITING ON TEESTA CAN BE PROBLEMATIC. SHE HAS A CHINA CARD TO PLAY IN IT

this for long. But India was conspicuously silent this time." His implication? The TMC is not the only one to be blamed for the impasse over the agreement.

Mamata is against committing any percentage of sharing Teesta water due to the precarious nature of its flow, as river expert Dr Kalyan Rudra has shown in his assessment. According to Rudra, Teesta on its downstream barely maintains even a minimum flow of 10 to 20 per cent in the dry months between November and April. Four dams on upstream Teesta and two more on Rangit, its tributary, all in Sikkim, are responsible. The Teesta barrage, set up in the '90s at Gajoldoba in Jalpaiguri district, to increase the irrigability of nine lakh hectares in Bengal, yielded negative results. Another barrage built at Duani in Bangladesh for expanding agriculture also hasn't worked due to paucity of water during the lean season. Experts like Rudra and Soumitra Ghosh estimated that agricultural activities over 1.6 million hectares (900,000 ha in Bengal and 700,000 ha in Bangladesh) would require1,600 cumecs (cubic meters per second) of water. At present, 100 cumecs of water is all the Teesta carries downstream in the dry spell. It can feed 48,000-50,000 ha.

When Modi came to power in 2014, he was committed to signing the Teesta agreement to strengthen ties with Bangladesh. But Mamata's staunch opposition to it means that nothing concrete has materialised.

Though Hasina had been consistently flagging the delay in sharing Teesta water in all her exchanges with Modi, there has been no encouraging response. Again, loss of political leverage in north Bengal is the issue, where the TMC faces charges of neglect by the BJP, thus feeding the demand for separate states or Union territories. But keeping Hasina waiting endlessly can be problematic, since she has done her bit—acting against anti-India insurgents and cooperating on counter-terrorism.

Bangladesh also has an ace up its sleeve: China. Since 2016, the country has been seriously thinking of seeking support from China on Teesta water management, a move that can be of strategic concern for India. Hasina's political opponents play up her closeness to India, not hesitating to point at the unresolved Teesta issue as a failure. "The water is emerging from the Indian side and India should show largeheartedness," was Hasina's stern parting shot in New Delhi. ■

PUNJAB

FIGHT FOR SURVIVAL

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

The country's oldest regional party—Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD)—is battling for survival, and so is its 'first family'. Ever since the Punjab assembly election results were declared in March this year, the 102-year-old party is witnessing internal rumblings of discontent against the leadership of the Badals.

From 56 seats in 2012, the SAD has been reduced to just three seats in the 117-member state legislative assembly. The Aam Aadmi Party wave that swept Punjab (it won 92 seats) also flooded the bastions of both the SAD president, Sukhbir Singh Badal, and his father and former five-time chief minister, Parkash Singh Badal. Besides the Badals, Sukhbir's two brothers-in-law—Adesh Partap Singh Kairon and Bikram Singh Majithia—also lost their seats, while the party could muster just over 18 per cent of the votes polled—its worst showing since 1966. After the Sangrur Lok Sabha byelection in June, which saw a splinter Akali group chief, Simranjit Singh Mann, emerge victorious and the SAD candidate relegated to the fifth position, the Badals find themselves cornered completely.

In mid-August, Sukhbir dissolved all the party units and offices, except his own. Many insiders say he smelled a coup. Now, in a last-ditch effort to revive the party's fortunes ahead of the 2024 general election and quell the simmering rebellion, the SAD chief has decided to go for a major organisational revamp. On September 2, he announced sweeping reforms within the party, though stopping short of a complete overhaul, as he virtually retained the top post for at least the next 10 years.